

A Gift to my Daughter: Coming Home after a Lifetime of Disconnection

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Placing Myself in Relation to the Vest

Over the course of the semester, I have spent my time beading regalia for my two-year-old daughter. Some other Nehiyawak (Cree people) would refer to beading as ceremony, but this semester, my beadwork became my medicine. While the beadwork patch is not very large, I spent the about 20 hours over the last three months beading a floral patch onto a Salish vest given to my daughter when she was born from kikawis (her aunt). As a piece of regalia, this vest has become a very special piece of clothing that has incorporated both sides of her Indigenous heritage.

I am Nehiyaw-Métis (Cree-Métis). While my maternal grandmother comes from the Samson Cree Nation in Treaty 6 and my maternal grandfather comes from the Saint Paul des Métis settlement in Treaty 6, I have not been on my own territories since I was about my daughter's age. I grew up in the child welfare system and aged out of care when I was 19 years old. I was taken for the first time from my maternal grandmother when I was four years old, and I was permanently taken and flown to Surrey, BC when I was 13 years old. I did not see any of my family for about 7 years after that. Since aging out of care, I have made many painstaking efforts to find my biological Indigenous family, find my community and raise my daughter within Cree ways of knowing, something that our peoples are deserving of and entitled to through our Treaty.

My daughters father is a member of the Lil'wat Nation. He grew up on the Mount Currie Reserve and is the child of a residential school survivor. When our daughter Avery (Kakwéla) was born, her aunt gave her the vest I submitted as a gift. The vest was worn by her cousin and

her aunt when they were young for feasting ceremonies in the Lil'wat community. The vest was worn to drumming circles, feasts and gatherings.

This gift to my daughter was a reminder to myself that as a youth in care, I did not have the opportunity to pass down childhood items, and specifically regalia, to my daughter, as I left care not knowing where I was from and no items to carry with me from my family. This gift inspired this project.

It is known amongst youth in care survivors that reconnection is an important pillar in life after navigating the child welfare system (Makokis et al., 2020). Reconnecting to my Cree community, nation and family is important for my daughter and I as it helps guide our path as we return "home", or back to our community, after being forcibly removed. This vest moved us on that path as it required me to reach out to my community to help me create it, and it gave my daughter an identifier that she always has her Nehiyaw, Métis and Lil'wat ancestors guiding and protecting her.

Giving the Vest a Spirit

This vest was created within academia, but this class integrated the creation of this vest with her Indigenous communities. My grandmother explained to me as I started beading the patch that I was giving spirit to the regalia I was creating for Avery. That every time I picked up my needles to bead that the intentions and the spirits that I surrounded myself with would become part of this vest. With that in mind, I made an effort to bead while I was in my lectures. I would bead while I was learning, in hopes that this vest will carry a spirit of learning carry my daughter and her family in a way of teaching.

Interestingly, while I was beading in Aboriginal and Treaty Rights, the Constitutional Express was spoken about in the lecture one day. This was a story that I was honoured to bead into my daughter's vest as it is one that is important to many Indigenous peoples, but particularly my daughter's father's family. My daughter's great-aunt, Atsie Pascal, who beaded this vest, was also a Lil'wat activist who participated in the constitutional express, and was arrested in Mount Currie for protesting during that time. Listening to the impacts of the efforts of her and her peers and how that shaped Aboriginal rights across the country was a reminder of the strength of our bloodlines. It is the strength I hope is carried in this vest.

I beaded two Métis flowers on the back of the vest. Guided by my community, I learnt how to flat stitch for the first time, and how to sew onto leather. I used two colours: pink and red. The red beads were chosen because they match the moccasins that my daughter was gifted by a friend of mine after she was born. I used pink as the other flower because I let my daughter help and that is the colour that she pulled from my tin of beads.

It is my hope that this vest can be continued to be passed down throughout our family as we continue as a family to reconnect to our people and find our way home. It is my hope that my daughter will never have to know the pain of being taken away, never having the stories and the gifts to give to her own children. These intentions and stories I hope are carried with this vest as it becomes hopefully the first only pieces that my family reclaims as we continue to reclaim.

Thank you for allowing me to do a project so meaningful and important to my daughter and I. This project really became a dream come true and something that I am so proud of, and I

cannot wait to tell my daughter about its creation when she is older. Kinanaskomitin Professor Jackson.

Bibliography

Makokis, L., Bodor, R., Calhoun, A., & Tyler, S. (2020). *ohpikinâwasowin: Growing a child : Implementing indigenous ways of knowing with indigenous families*. Fernwood Publishing.